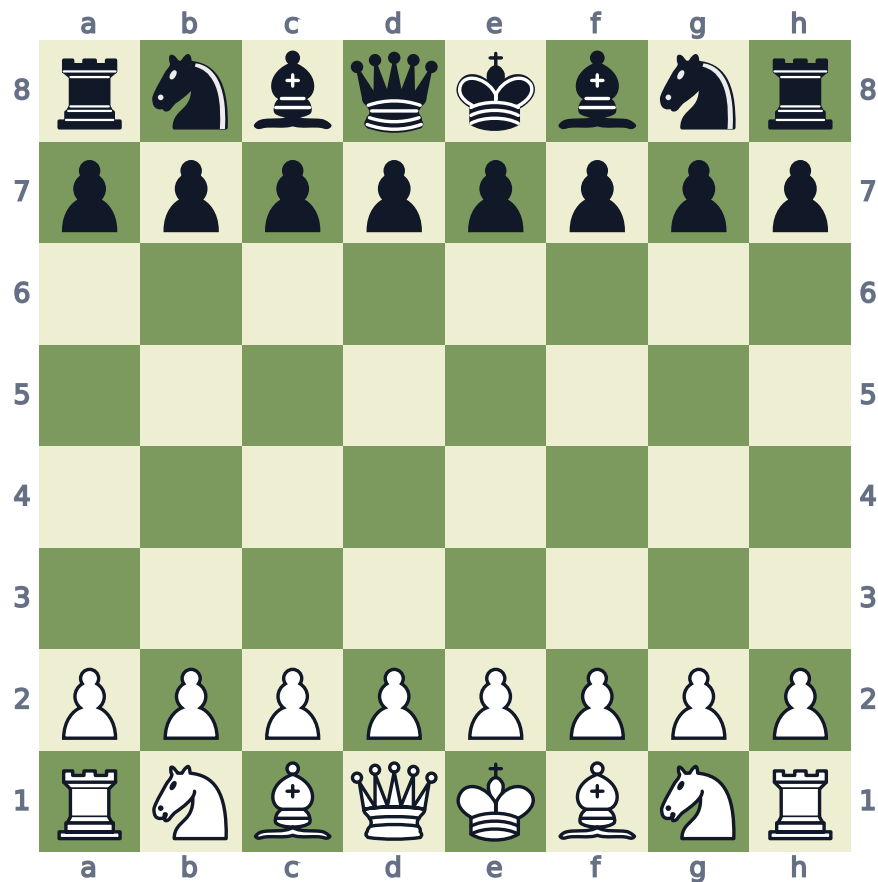


Chess Improvement Workbook

Assessment, exercises, scorecards, and review schedules



Convert the entire library into practice with structured prompts, board laboratories, error classification, spaced review, and weekly planning.

75 learning units | explanations | board laboratories | review system

ORIENTATION

What this course will change

COURSE PROMISE

Convert the entire library into practice with structured prompts, board laboratories, error classification, spaced review, and weekly planning.

YOU WILL LEARN TO

- Diagnose strengths and weaknesses
- Practice every course actively
- Score decision quality separately from results
- Build a repeatable twelve-week improvement cycle

HOW TO USE THE COURSE

- Study one learning unit at a time. Say the rule in your own words before continuing.
- At each diagram, hide the model answer. Write candidates and the opponent's best reply.
- Use the rule during a slow game, then record whether it actually changed a decision.
- Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days. Retrieval matters more than rereading.

SCOPE

This course contains 75 integrated learning units. Principles guide attention, but tactics and exact calculation always decide the move.

CORE METHOD

The decision protocol

USE THIS EVERY TIME

A reliable process is more valuable than a brilliant idea used occasionally. Practice the sequence until it becomes automatic under clock pressure.

1**State the position's problem.****2****Generate candidates.****3****Calculate the best reply.****4****Evaluate the endpoint.****5****Record the lesson and schedule a review.****STOPPING RULE**

Choose when one candidate is sufficiently verified for the clock situation. Before moving, inspect the position once from the opponent's perspective.

BASELINE

Score your current process

- 0 never | 1 sometimes | 2 usually | 3 automatic I identify the opponent's threat before choosing my move.
- 0 never | 1 sometimes | 2 usually | 3 automatic I generate more than one candidate in critical positions.
- 0 never | 1 sometimes | 2 usually | 3 automatic I calculate the opponent's strongest resistance.
- 0 never | 1 sometimes | 2 usually | 3 automatic I can evaluate the resulting position after a forcing line.
- 0 never | 1 sometimes | 2 usually | 3 automatic I know the main pawn breaks in my openings.
- 0 never | 1 sometimes | 2 usually | 3 automatic I recognize the essential king-and-pawn and rook endings.
- 0 never | 1 sometimes | 2 usually | 3 automatic I analyze serious games before using an engine.
- 0 never | 1 sometimes | 2 usually | 3 automatic I review recurring mistakes with a specific drill.

INTERPRETATION

0-8: build the decision process first. 9-16: target the two lowest areas. 17-24: use harder positions and stricter time limits. Retest after four weeks; measure behavior, not only rating.

WORKBOOK SECTION 01

The Anti-Blunder Course

PURPOSE

Replace hope-based chess with a compact routine that catches threats, loose pieces, tactical replies, and thinking errors before they become losses.

- 01.1** Tactics Come Before Strategy: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.
- 01.2** Compare Moves, Do Not Defend Your First Idea: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.
- 01.3** Verify the Best Defense: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.
- 01.4** Calculate the Best Countercheck First: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.
- 01.5** Separate Seeing Errors from Judging Errors: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 01

Think, record, then compare



2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 01

Rubrics, not guesses

- 01.1** Full credit requires the rule (Before choosing a strategic plan, verify that no forcing tactic changes the position immediately.), the reason (A beautiful long-term plan has no value if a check, capture, or direct threat wins material first. Tactical facts define which strategic choices are legal.), a cue (An exposed king; loose pieces; contact between opposing pieces; a recent pawn move that opened a line.), and the limitation (Do not calculate random checks forever. Once forcing lines are exhausted, return to evaluation and planning.).
- 01.2** Full credit requires the rule (Try to disprove each candidate and compare resulting positions instead of collecting reasons to like the first move.), the reason (Confirmation bias makes weak moves feel increasingly convincing. Adversarial comparison asks which move survives the opponent's strongest response.), a cue (You feel emotionally attached to a move; a sacrifice looks exciting; two candidates have different risks.), and the limitation (Comparison still needs a stopping rule. In practical play, choose once one move is clearly adequate and time is...)
- 01.3** Full credit requires the rule (Judge a combination against the opponent's strongest resource, not the reply you hope to see.), the reason (Optimistic calculation inflates attacks. Strong defense may return material, trade queens, countercheck, or decline a sacrifice.), a cue (You think you found a win; a sacrifice begins the line; the opponent has several legal replies.), and the limitation (Do not spend equal time on clearly inferior defenses. Search first for moves that challenge your assumption most directly.).
- 01.4** Full credit requires the rule (When attacking, test the opponent's strongest check before assuming they must answer your threat.), the reason (Checks can reverse move order, expose your king, or force a perpetual before your attack lands. Examining the most dangerous countercheck first stress-tests the branch at its weakest point and prevents wishful one-sided calculation.), a cue (the position has several plausible forcing continuations; one branch depends on a long visualization; the opponent has an active tactical reply), and the limitation (Do not...
- 01.5** Full credit requires the rule (Classify a calculation miss as visualization, candidate generation, or evaluation-not simply 'a blunder.'), the reason (Different failures require different training. Misplacing a piece calls for visualization drills; never considering the move calls for candidate work; reaching the position but judging it wrongly calls for evaluation study.), a cue (the position has several plausible forcing continuations; one branch depends on a long visualization; the opponent has an active tactical reply), and the limitation (Do not calculate mechanically to a fix...

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 02

Tactical Patterns Encyclopedia

PURPOSE

Learn tactics as geometric mechanisms rather than puzzle tricks, then connect each motif to a disciplined calculation method.

02.1 Calculate Forcing Lines First: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

02.2 Remove the Defender: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

02.3 Discovered Attacks Release Hidden Force: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

02.4 Use the Desperado Before Losing a Trapped Piece: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

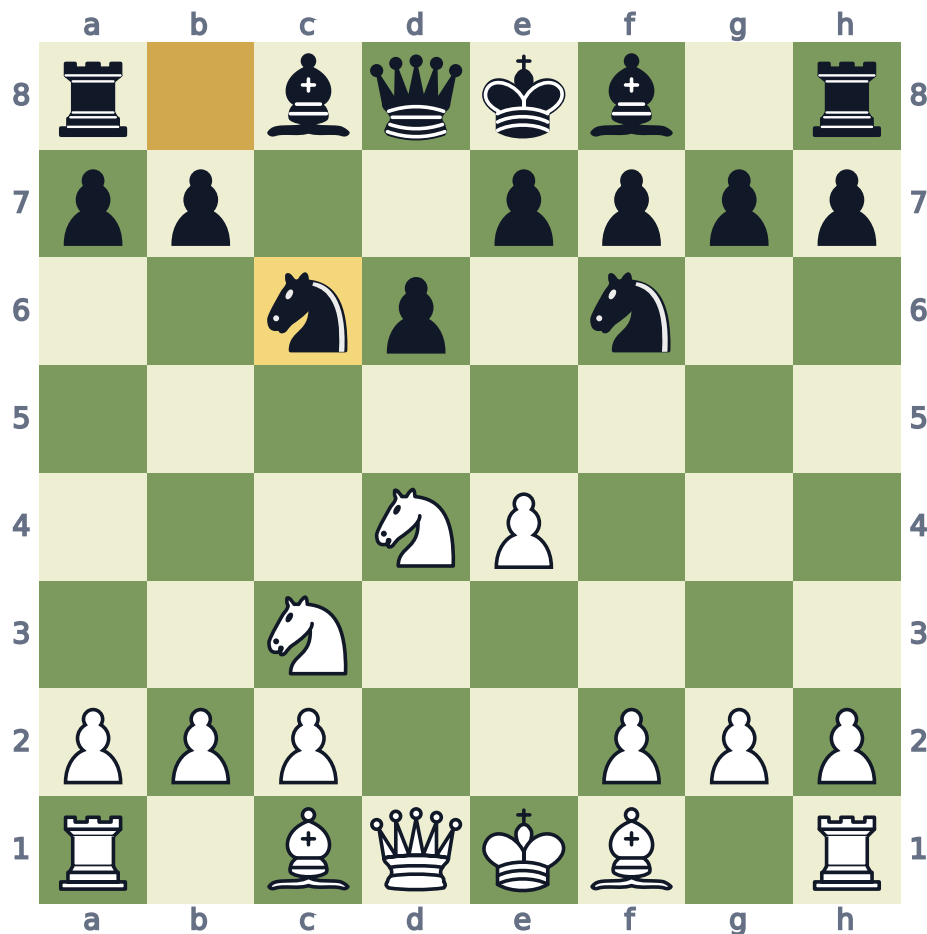
02.5 Build the Mating Net Before Checking: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 02

Think, record, then compare



3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 02

Rubrics, not guesses

02.1 Full credit requires the rule (Analyze moves that sharply restrict replies before branching into quiet alternatives.), the reason (Checks, tactical captures, and immediate threats produce narrower trees, so accurate depth is possible with less cognitive load.), a cue (King exposure; hanging material; mating nets; tactical races; contact captures.), and the limitation (Forcing does not mean sound. Rank candidates by relevance after listing them.).

02.2 Full credit requires the rule (When a target is adequately protected, calculate whether its key defender can be exchanged, deflected, pinned, or distracted.), the reason (Attacks often fail because one defensive unit holds the structure together. Removing that unit changes the arithmetic of every follow-up.), a cue (A mating square has one guard; a passed pawn is blockaded by one piece; a tactical target is defended exactly once.), and the limitation (Trading for a defender can surrender a valuable attacker. Compare the remaining pieces after the exchange.).

02.3 Full credit requires the rule (Move the blocking piece with tempo so a rook, bishop, or queen attacks through the newly opened line.), the reason (The moving unit and revealed line act simultaneously. This creates two threats with one move and often overloads the defender's ability to answer both.), a cue (Pieces align on a rank, file, or diagonal; one unit has limited mobility; a forcing move can alter the line), and the limitation (A visible motif is only a candidate. Verify every legal defense, intermediate move, and resulting material balance before committing.).

02.4 Full credit requires the rule (When a piece is certain to be lost, seek checks, captures, or structural damage before allowing its removal.), the reason (A doomed piece still has temporary move value. Converting that final tempo into material or damage reduces the net cost of the loss and can alter move order.), a cue (Pieces align on a rank, file, or diagonal; one unit has limited mobility; a forcing move can alter the line), and the limitation (A visible motif is only a candidate. Verify every legal defense, intermediate move, and resulting material balance before...)

02.5 Full credit requires the rule (Restrict the king's exits before spending the checks that drive it.), the reason (Checks without control can help a king escape. A mating net works by reducing legal squares until every check becomes more forcing and defensive interpositions no longer create an exit route.), a cue (a king has limited squares; one piece performs two defensive jobs; a line could open with tempo; a forcing move changes the geometry), and the limitation (A familiar motif is only a search cue. Confirm the legal move order, the opponent's best defense, and...)

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 03

Calculation From the Ground Up

PURPOSE

Build a calculation process that is deep enough to be accurate, narrow enough to be practical, and explicit enough to improve after every game.

03.1 Visualize the Position After Every Forcing Move: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

03.2 Calculate Capture Order Precisely: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

03.3 Distinguish Forced Moves From Merely Natural Moves: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

03.4 Calculate the Best Countercheck First: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

03.5 Return to the Root Between Branches: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 03

Think, record, then compare



1... c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 03

Rubrics, not guesses

03.1 Full credit requires the rule (Rebuild the board mentally after each move instead of carrying an outdated image forward.), the reason (Calculation errors often come from ghost pieces, forgotten captures, and lines that are no longer blocked. Explicit board updating preserves legal geometry.), a cue (Several candidates deserve analysis; the position contains forcing continuations; the final evaluation is not obvious), and the limitation (A disciplined method should reduce error, not consume unlimited time. Stop when one move is sufficiently verified for the...)

03.2 Full credit requires the rule (When several exchanges are possible, test different capture and recapture sequences.), the reason (Move order changes which piece occupies the square, which lines open, and whether an intermediate tactic exists. Identical material exchanges can yield different positions.), a cue (Several candidates deserve analysis; the position contains forcing continuations; the final evaluation is not obvious), and the limitation (A disciplined method should reduce error, not consume unlimited time. Stop when one move is sufficiently veri...)

03.3 Full credit requires the rule (Label replies as forced only when all alternatives fail concretely.), the reason (Calling a natural reply forced creates imaginary combinations. Strong defenders often choose an ugly move, return material, or decline the expected capture.), a cue (Several candidates deserve analysis; the position contains forcing continuations; the final evaluation is not obvious), and the limitation (A disciplined method should reduce error, not consume unlimited time. Stop when one move is sufficiently verified for the practical situation.).

03.4 Full credit requires the rule (When attacking, test the opponent's strongest check before assuming they must answer your threat.), the reason (Checks can reverse move order, expose your king, or force a perpetual before your attack lands. Examining the most dangerous countercheck first stress-tests the branch at its weakest point and prevents wishful one-sided calculation.), a cue (the position has several plausible forcing continuations; one branch depends on a long visualization; the opponent has an active tactical reply), and the limitation (Do not...)

03.5 Full credit requires the rule (After calculating one candidate, mentally reset every piece before starting the next.), the reason (Visualization residue causes pieces from one imagined line to leak into another. Reconstructing the original position restores accurate geometry and makes comparisons between candidates independent.), a cue (the position has several plausible forcing continuations; one branch depends on a long visualization; the opponent has an active tactical reply), and the limitation (Do not calculate mechanically to a fixed depth. Stop a...)

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 04

Essential Endgames

PURPOSE

Master the positions that must be known, while learning how to calculate unfamiliar endings from king activity, pawn races, checking geometry, and counterplay.

04.1 Activate the King: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

04.2 Bishops Gain Value on Both Wings: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

04.3 Use the Philidor Third-Rank Defense: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

04.4 Preserve a Reserve Tempo: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

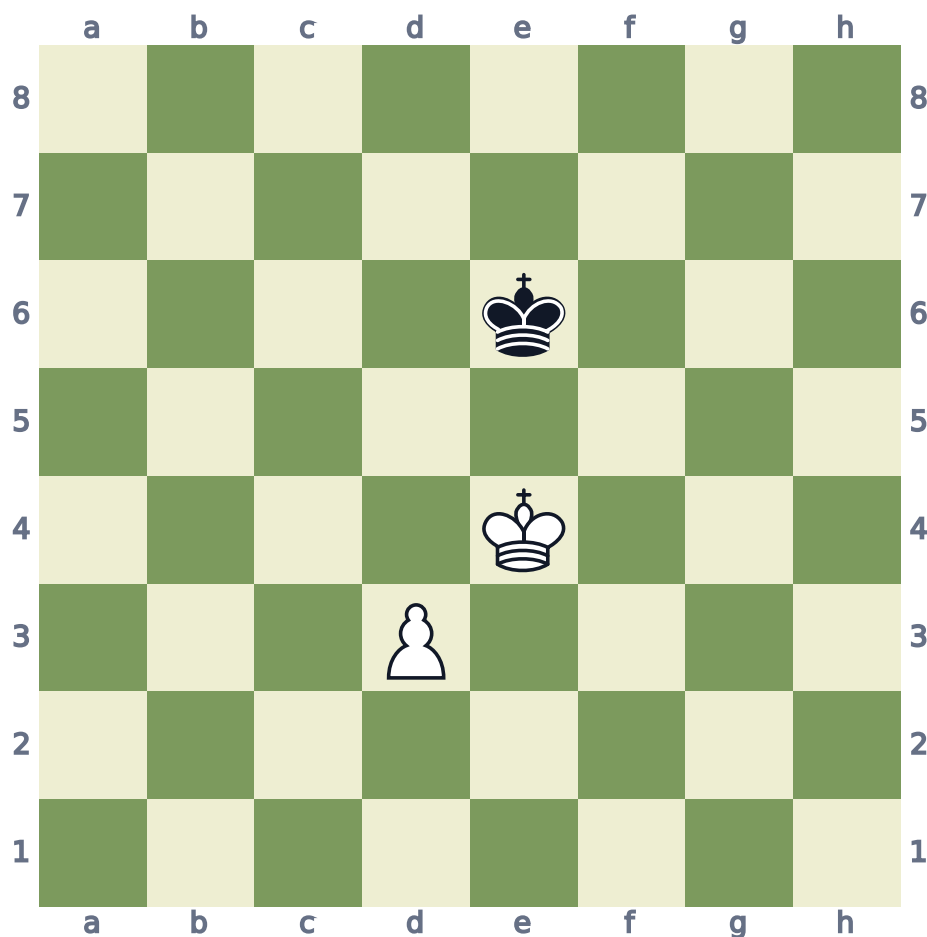
04.5 Learn the Vancura Defense: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 04

Think, record, then compare



Exact endgame laboratory

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 04

Rubrics, not guesses

04.1 Full credit requires the rule (Use the king as a fighting piece once mating danger and queens are reduced.), the reason (The king attacks pawns, supports passers, controls entry squares, and often outweighs a distant minor piece in local battles.), a cue (Queens traded; few pieces remain; king can approach the center safely.), and the limitation (Do not centralize into tactical checks, mating nets, or a lost pawn race.).

04.2 Full credit requires the rule (Keep play on both flanks when your bishop can switch faster than the opponent's knight or king.), the reason (Long-range movement lets a bishop influence separated targets in one move, increasing the cost of defending two wings.), a cue (Queens and rooks are gone or can be exchanged; pawn color and wing distribution matter; king routes and piece limitations dominate), and the limitation (Minor-piece endings contain tactical races. Calculate pawn breakthroughs, sacrifices, and zugzwangs before applying a general rule.).

04.3 Full credit requires the rule (Keep the defending rook active on the third rank until the stronger king advances, then check from behind.), the reason (The setup prevents king shelter and preserves checking distance. Timing the retreat avoids passive front-blockade failure.), a cue (Heavy pieces remain with exposed kings or passed pawns; checking distance and activity matter; a technical position is approaching), and the limitation (Heavy-piece endings are check-sensitive. A single tempo, checking angle, or king exposure can outweigh a pawn or textbook...

04.4 Full credit requires the rule (Keep an unnecessary pawn move available when the position may become zugzwang.), the reason (A spare pawn step passes the move without changing the critical king geometry. Spending it too early can reverse the opposition and turn a win into a draw or a draw into a loss.), a cue (few pieces remain; a king can approach a critical square; a pawn race or zugzwang is possible; one pawn move may spend the last reserve tempo), and the limitation (Endgame rules are exact only under their stated conditions....

04.5 Full credit requires the rule (Against a rook pawn and rook, check the king from the side before it can shelter behind the pawn.), the reason (The Vancura setup draws by combining lateral checks with attacks on the pawn. Adequate side distance prevents the winning king from escaping checks while the defending king stays near promotion.), a cue (a rook or queen must give checks; a king can be cut off; an exchange could enter a pawn ending; the defender still has active counterplay), and the limitation (Do not simplify merely because you are...

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 05

Pawn-Structure Atlas

PURPOSE

Use the pawn skeleton as a map of where pieces belong, which exchanges help, and which breaks will change the position.

05.1 A Pawn Center Is Both Asset and Target: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

05.2 Open Lines When Your Pieces Are Better: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

05.3 A Backward Pawn Is Weak Only If It Can Be Attacked: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

05.4 French Chains Create Opposite-Wing Plans: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

05.5 Advance Hanging Pawns with Purpose: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 05

Think, record, then compare



4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 Nf6 6. Bc4 d5

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 05

Rubrics, not guesses

05.1 Full credit requires the rule (Use a broad pawn center for space, but support it because the opponent will attack its base and advance points.), the reason (Central pawns restrict enemy pieces and support expansion, yet every advanced pawn can be undermined and cannot retreat.), a cue (You occupy two central squares; the opponent uses hypermodern development; pawn breaks are approaching.), and the limitation (Do not spend all your pieces defending pawns. Sometimes exchanging or advancing restores activity.).

05.2 Full credit requires the rule (Transform superior activity into concrete access by opening files and diagonals.), the reason (Active pieces gain value as mobility increases. Opening lines forces the opponent to solve threats before reorganizing inferior pieces.), a cue (Your rooks and bishops are aligned; opponent's pieces are passive; a pawn exchange can open a line.), and the limitation (Do not open a line that primarily activates the opponent's dormant bishop or rook.).

05.3 Full credit requires the rule (Evaluate a backward pawn by accessibility, fixing power, and available breaks, not by shape alone.), the reason (A nominal weakness matters only when the opponent can attack it and the owner must defend passively. If it can advance safely, the defect may disappear.), a cue (Pawn lacks neighbors; enemy controls its advance square; a file can be occupied by rooks.), and the limitation (Do not spend many moves attacking a pawn that is easily defended while the opponent gains activity elsewhere.).

05.4 Full credit requires the rule (Follow the locked central chain toward the wing where your space points and attack the chain's base from the other side.), the reason (Interlocking e- and d-pawns fix central movement. This directs White toward kingside space and Black toward queenside and central breaks.), a cue (The pawn skeleton matches a familiar family; standard breaks and outposts are visible; piece plans follow from fixed pawn geometry), and the limitation (Structures guide plans but exact piece placement changes everything. Confirm that the...

05.5 Full credit requires the rule (Move one hanging pawn only when the advance gains space, creates a passer, or supports a concrete break.), the reason (Side-by-side pawns control important squares and can advance dynamically. Once one moves, the other may become backward and the vacated squares weak, so the transformation must create immediate value.), a cue (the central pawns define fixed chains or islands; a thematic pawn break is available; exchanges may transform the structure), and the limitation (Typical plans can fail...

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 06

How to Form a Plan

PURPOSE

Turn positional observations into a plan by choosing an actionable imbalance, improving coordination, and accounting for the opponent's counterplay.

06.1 Knights Need Stable Outposts: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

06.2 Coordinate the Queen With Minor Pieces: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

06.3 Activity Can Outweigh Structural Damage: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

06.4 A Weakness Requires Access: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

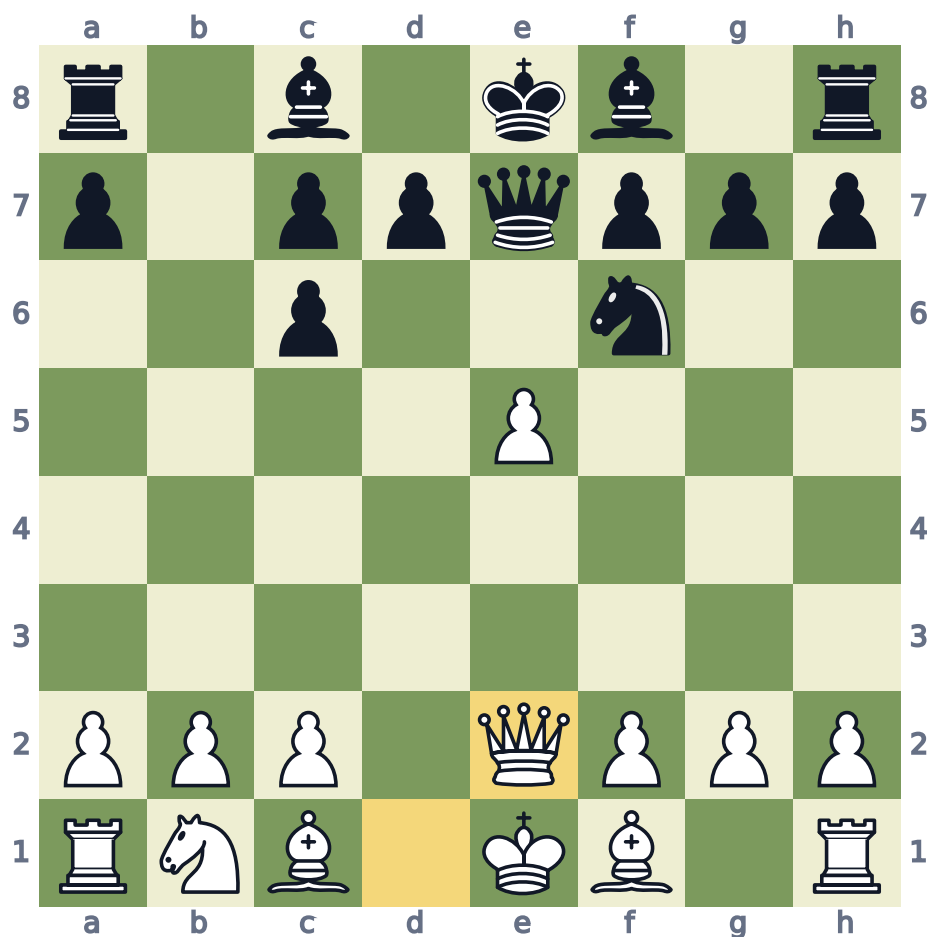
06.5 Penetrate on the Open File: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 06

Think, record, then compare



4... Nf6 5. Nxc6 bxc6 6. e5 Qe7 7. Qe2

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 06

Rubrics, not guesses

06.1 Full credit requires the rule (Route knights toward protected central squares that enemy pawns cannot attack.), the reason (Knights are strongest when their short range reaches important targets without being chased. Stability converts temporary placement into lasting pressure.), a cue (Closed center; pawn-created hole; protected square on the fifth or sixth rank.), and the limitation (A knight on the rim can be excellent if it has a concrete route or target. Central appearance alone is not enough.).

06.2 Full credit requires the rule (Use the queen to amplify piece pressure rather than operating alone.), the reason (A coordinated queen creates batteries, double attacks, and mating nets while minor pieces cover squares the queen cannot occupy safely.), a cue (Bishop points toward king; knight controls flight squares; queen can join without being chased.), and the limitation (Queen activity can become exposure. If minor pieces are undeveloped, the queen may simply provide the opponent tempi.).

06.3 Full credit requires the rule (Accept a structural defect when it produces sustained piece activity or open lines that the opponent cannot neutralize.), the reason (Weak pawns matter only if they can be attacked. Active pieces may seize the initiative, create threats, and prevent the opponent from organizing against the structure.), a cue (No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame), and the limitation (Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a sta...

06.4 Full credit requires the rule (Call a pawn or square weak only when the opponent can reach and exploit it without excessive cost.), the reason (Static labels become meaningful through routes. If no piece can attack the weakness or invasion square is unavailable, the defect may be irrelevant.), a cue (No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame), and the limitation (Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and...

06.5 Full credit requires the rule (Double rooks or invade only when doing so creates a concrete target, tie-down, or favorable exchange.), the reason (Heavy pieces gain value from access. Penetration forces defensive passivity and attacks pawns from the side or rear, whereas an open file with no entry points may be strategically irrelevant.), a cue (there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target), and the limitation (Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break,...

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 07

Attacking Chess

PURPOSE

Learn when an attack is justified, how to bring pieces into the king zone, how to remove defenders, and when to convert pressure into a safer gain.

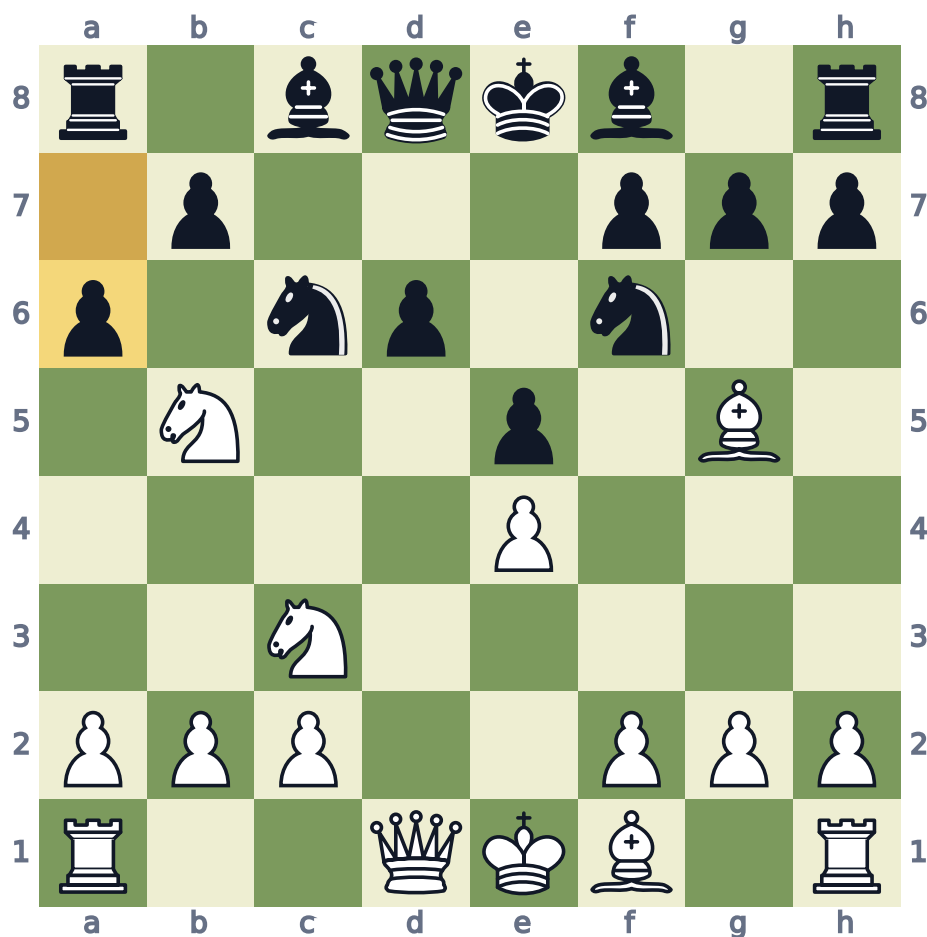
- 07.1** Bring More Pieces Than the Defender: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.
- 07.2** Create a Second Weakness: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.
- 07.3** Challenge the Base of a Fianchetto: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.
- 07.4** Offer a Queen Trade to Break the Attack: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.
- 07.5** Build the Mating Net Before Checking: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 07

Think, record, then compare



5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 07

Rubrics, not guesses

07.1 Full credit requires the rule (Build local superiority around the target before sacrificing or opening lines.), the reason (Attacks succeed when more effective force reaches the zone than the defense can organize. An unused rook or bishop is often the missing attacker.), a cue (Enemy king has limited defenders; pieces can transfer with tempo; lines can be opened.), and the limitation (Raw piece count ignores quality and forcing moves. One powerful defender can neutralize several poorly placed attackers.).

07.2 Full credit requires the rule (When one target is fully defended, open play on the opposite wing or create another permanent problem.), the reason (A defender can hold one weakness by concentration. Two distant weaknesses stretch pieces beyond their ideal defensive squares.), a cue (Opponent is tied to one pawn; direct breakthrough fails; you have space to switch wings.), and the limitation (Do not abandon a winning direct method to create unnecessary complications. The second weakness should be real and accessible.).

07.3 Full credit requires the rule (Attack the pawn and bishop complex supporting a fianchettoed king rather than sacrificing automatically on the shelter.), the reason (The fianchetto bishop guards key color squares. Exchanging it or undermining its pawns can create lasting entry squares for queen and minor pieces.), a cue (One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds), and the limitation (King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and...

07.4 Full credit requires the rule (When defending, use a queen exchange threat to force the attacker to lose time or abandon key squares.), the reason (Most mating attacks require queens. Even a declined exchange can displace the attacking queen and interrupt coordination.), a cue (One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds), and the limitation (King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual...

07.5 Full credit requires the rule (Restrict the king's exits before spending the checks that drive it.), the reason (Checks without control can help a king escape. A mating net works by reducing legal squares until every check becomes more forcing and defensive interpositions no longer create an exit route.), a cue (a king has limited squares; one piece performs two defensive jobs; a line could open with tempo; a forcing move changes the geometry), and the limitation (A familiar motif is only a search cue. Confirm the legal move order, the opponent's best defense, and...

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 08

Defensive Chess and Prophylaxis

PURPOSE

Defend without panic by naming the threat, reducing the attacker's options, returning material when necessary, and creating active counterplay.

08.1 Identify the Real Threat: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

08.2 Create a Flight Square: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

08.3 Ask What the Opponent Wants: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

08.4 Use an Open Rook-Pawn File Against the King: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

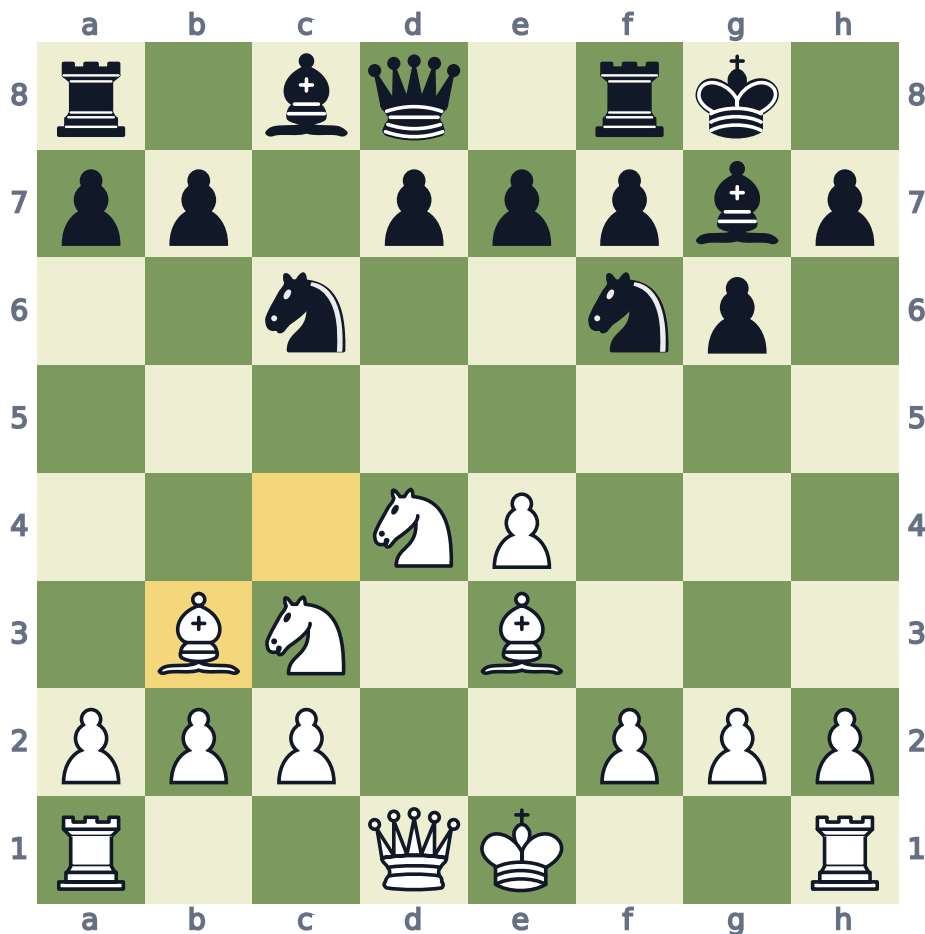
08.5 Blockade the Pawn Storm: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 08

Think, record, then compare



5... Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Bc4 O-O 8. Bb3

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 08

Rubrics, not guesses

08.1 Full credit requires the rule (Name the opponent's concrete threat and its required conditions before choosing a defense.), the reason (Fear produces passive moves against imaginary dangers. Precise threat identification reveals whether to prevent, ignore, counter, or exploit the idea.), a cue (Opponent moves near your king; sacrifice seems possible; several defensive moves tempt you.), and the limitation (Some threats are positional rather than tactical. Include pawn breaks, exchanges, and improved piece placement.).

08.2 Full credit requires the rule (Give the king an escape square when back-rank or mating-net danger is concrete.), the reason (A single legal retreat can remove entire tactical themes and free rooks from passive defense.), a cue (King boxed by pawns; enemy rook or queen controls entry line; back-rank tactics are possible.), and the limitation (Pawn moves around the king create holes and cost time. Create luft only when its value exceeds those costs.).

08.3 Full credit requires the rule (Before executing your own plan, identify the opponent's best improvement and consider preventing it cheaply.), the reason (Prophylaxis reduces the opponent's strongest options while preserving your plan. It is efficient control of future possibilities.), a cue (Quiet position; opponent has a clear break or piece route; one useful move can hinder it.), and the limitation (Do not spend tempi stopping harmless plans. Prevention should be cheaper than the danger prevented.).

08.4 Full credit requires the rule (Place a rook or queen on an opened h- or a-file when it leads directly to the castled king.), the reason (Pawn exchanges can create a straight attacking highway. Control of the entry square and the defender's rook-pawn geometry determine whether it is decisive.), a cue (One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds), and the limitation (King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trustin...

08.5 Full credit requires the rule (Stop attacking pawns on fixed squares before they can open files against your king.), the reason (A blocked pawn can become a shield for the defender and a target for pieces. Restraint buys time for central or opposite-wing counterplay.), a cue (One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds), and the limitation (King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.).

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 09

Converting an Advantage

PURPOSE

Preserve what is valuable, remove counterplay, improve the least effective unit, and transform the position only when the destination is demonstrably favorable.

09.1 Trade One Advantage for a More Usable One: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

09.2 Restrain Before You Blockade: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

09.3 Evaluate the Resulting Position: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

09.4 Create a Passed Pawn From a Majority: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

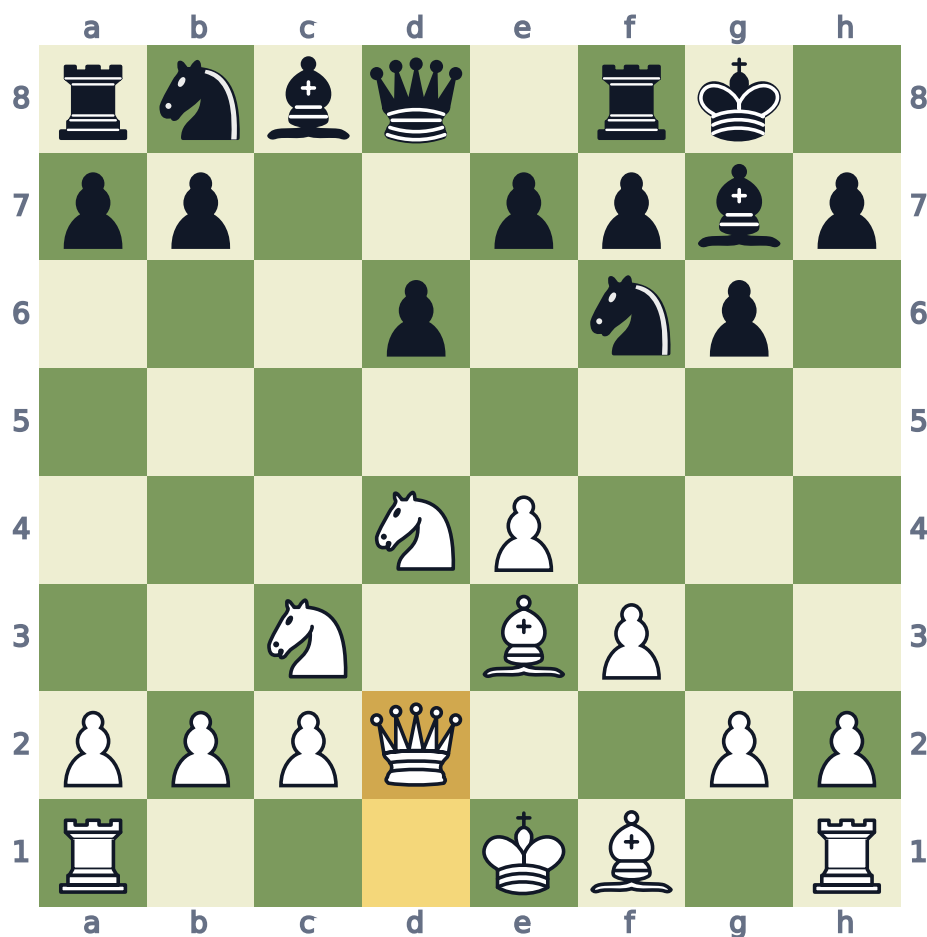
09.5 Launch a Pawn Storm Only With Central Security: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 09

Think, record, then compare



5... g6 6. Be3 Bg7 7. f3 O-O 8. Qd2

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 09

Rubrics, not guesses

09.1 Full credit requires the rule (Convert temporary activity, space, or initiative into material, structure, or a favorable ending before it fades.), the reason (Advantages are resources that can change form. The strongest conversion is not always the largest immediate gain, but the one easiest to sustain.), a cue (A trade, pawn break, or simplification can change the type of advantage; one plan is reaching its limit; a favorable ending is available), and the limitation (Transformation is valuable only when the destination position preserves a usable advantage....)

09.2 Full credit requires the rule (Stop enemy pawn mobility before occupying the ideal blockading square.), the reason (Restraint fixes the target and denies freeing breaks. Only then can a blockader settle without being chased or bypassed.), a cue (A trade, pawn break, or simplification can change the type of advantage; one plan is reaching its limit; a favorable ending is available), and the limitation (Transformation is valuable only when the destination position preserves a usable advantage. Calculate the transition, not just the current position.).

09.3 Full credit requires the rule (Judge a move by the position it produces, not by how active or attractive the move looks.), the reason (Moves exchange one advantage for another: material for activity, space for weaknesses, or simplification for an endgame. The destination position contains the real cost.), a cue (A combination ends; queens may be traded; a pawn break changes structure; a move wins material but loses activity.), and the limitation (Evaluation cannot replace calculation when the resulting position still contains forcing moves.).

09.4 Full credit requires the rule (Use a local pawn majority to exchange opposing pawns and leave one passer.), the reason (A numerical advantage on one wing can be converted through correct move order. The potential passer creates a second front even before it advances.), a cue (Three pawns face two; kings are active; pawn exchanges can be forced.), and the limitation (A majority can be immobilized or create weak pawns if advanced carelessly. Calculate the exchange structure first.).

09.5 Full credit requires the rule (Advance wing pawns when the center is closed, your king is elsewhere, or central counterplay is controlled.), the reason (Pawn storms gain space and open lines, but they consume tempi and leave squares. A stable center prevents the opponent from striking more efficiently.), a cue (Opposite-side castling; locked center; pieces support the pawn advance.), and the limitation (A tactical pawn push may be correct even in an open center, but it requires concrete calculation.).

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 10

Mastering Exchanges

PURPOSE

Stop exchanging automatically. Judge trades by the pieces that remain, the pawn ending that may result, the color complexes that change, and the opponent's remaining activity.

10.1 Evaluate the Resulting Position: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

10.2 Verify the Best Defense: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

10.3 Create a Passed Pawn From a Majority: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

10.4 Exchange the Opponent's Most Active Piece: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

10.5 Return Material to Neutralize the Initiative: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

Think, record, then compare



1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats.
2. List three candidates.
3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each.
4. Evaluate each endpoint.
5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 10

Rubrics, not guesses

- 10.1** Full credit requires the rule (Judge a move by the position it produces, not by how active or attractive the move looks.), the reason (Moves exchange one advantage for another: material for activity, space for weaknesses, or simplification for an endgame. The destination position contains the real cost.), a cue (A combination ends; queens may be traded; a pawn break changes structure; a move wins material but loses activity.), and the limitation (Evaluation cannot replace calculation when the resulting position still contains forcing moves.).
- 10.2** Full credit requires the rule (Judge a combination against the opponent's strongest resource, not the reply you hope to see.), the reason (Optimistic calculation inflates attacks. Strong defense may return material, trade queens, countercheck, or decline a sacrifice.), a cue (You think you found a win; a sacrifice begins the line; the opponent has several legal replies.), and the limitation (Do not spend equal time on clearly inferior defenses. Search first for moves that challenge your assumption most directly.).
- 10.3** Full credit requires the rule (Use a local pawn majority to exchange opposing pawns and leave one passer.), the reason (A numerical advantage on one wing can be converted through correct move order. The potential passer creates a second front even before it advances.), a cue (Three pawns face two; kings are active; pawn exchanges can be forced.), and the limitation (A majority can be immobilized or create weak pawns if advanced carelessly. Calculate the exchange structure first.).
- 10.4** Full credit requires the rule (When under positional pressure, seek a favorable trade of the enemy piece doing the most work.), the reason (Removing the active unit reduces threats and may expose the weakness it was supporting. Activity, not nominal piece value, determines urgency.), a cue (One knight dominates an outpost; a bishop controls both wings; a rook occupies the seventh rank.), and the limitation (Do not trade your only active defender or enter a worse pawn ending merely to remove an impressive piece.).
- 10.5** Full credit requires the rule (Give back extra material when it completes development, trades attackers, or removes king danger.), the reason (Holding every pawn can force passivity and allow the initiative to grow. Returning part of the gain can convert a dangerous position into a stable one.), a cue (You are materially ahead but undeveloped; king is exposed; opponent has strong piece activity.), and the limitation (Do not surrender material automatically. Calculate whether accurate defense preserves both safety and the extra material.).

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 11

Piece-by-Piece Mastery

PURPOSE

Understand each unit as a problem-solving tool: what it needs from the pawn structure, what limits it, and how it coordinates with the rest of the army.

11.1 Treat Pawn Moves as Permanent Commitments: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

11.2 Plan Knight Routes Several Moves Ahead: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

11.3 Use the Bishop Pair in Open Positions: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

11.4 Coordinate the Queen With Smaller Pieces: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

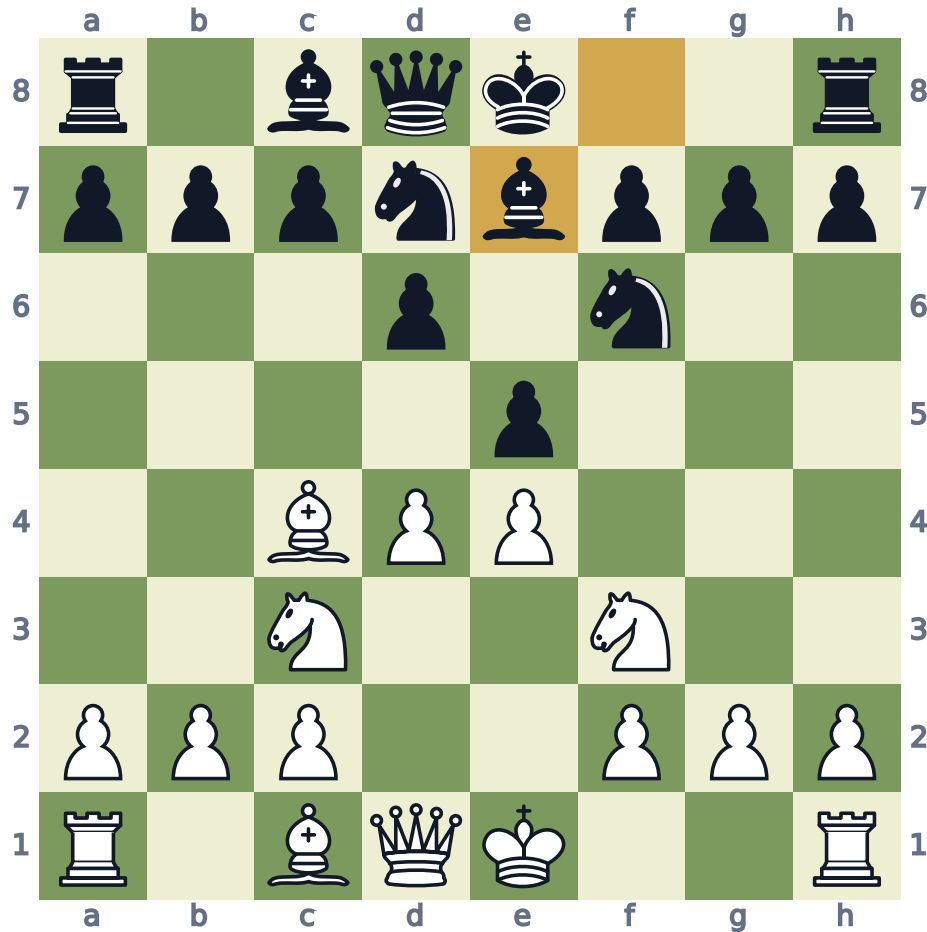
11.5 Activate the King as Material Disappears: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 11

Think, record, then compare



3. d4 Nf6 4. Nc3 Nbd7 5. Bc4 Be7

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 11

Rubrics, not guesses

11.1 Full credit requires the rule (Move a pawn only after naming the squares, lines, and future breaks that the move changes.), the reason (Pawns cannot retreat, so every advance gains something and abandons something. Their fixed geometry becomes the map for every other piece.), a cue (The pawns determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.), and the limitation (Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.).

11.2 Full credit requires the rule (Name the destination square first, then calculate the safest route and whether it arrives in time.), the reason (Knights often require two or three moves to improve. A route is justified when the position stays closed enough and the destination changes the struggle.), a cue (The knights determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.), and the limitation (Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.).

11.3 Full credit requires the rule (Preserve two bishops when the center is likely to open and targets exist on both colors.), the reason (Two bishops coordinate across both color complexes and can switch wings quickly. Their advantage grows as pawns are exchanged and lines lengthen.), a cue (The bishops determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.), and the limitation (Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.).

11.4 Full credit requires the rule (Use the queen to multiply existing pressure rather than attack alone.), the reason (The queen is powerful but vulnerable to tempo attacks. Coordination with bishops, knights, and rooks creates threats that cannot be answered by chasing one piece.), a cue (The queens determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.), and the limitation (Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.).

11.5 Full credit requires the rule (Centralize the king once checks and mating threats no longer dominate.), the reason (The king becomes a strong short-range piece in endings. Early activation saves tempi and supports pawns, but the transition must be timed precisely.), a cue (The kings determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.), and the limitation (Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.).

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 12

Annotated Model-Game Laboratories

PURPOSE

Study complete strategic stories instead of isolated moves: opening purpose, structural transition, piece improvement, tactical turning point, and end-of-line evaluation.

12.1 Italian Game: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

12.2 Scotch Game: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

12.3 Vienna Game: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

12.4 Petrov Defense: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

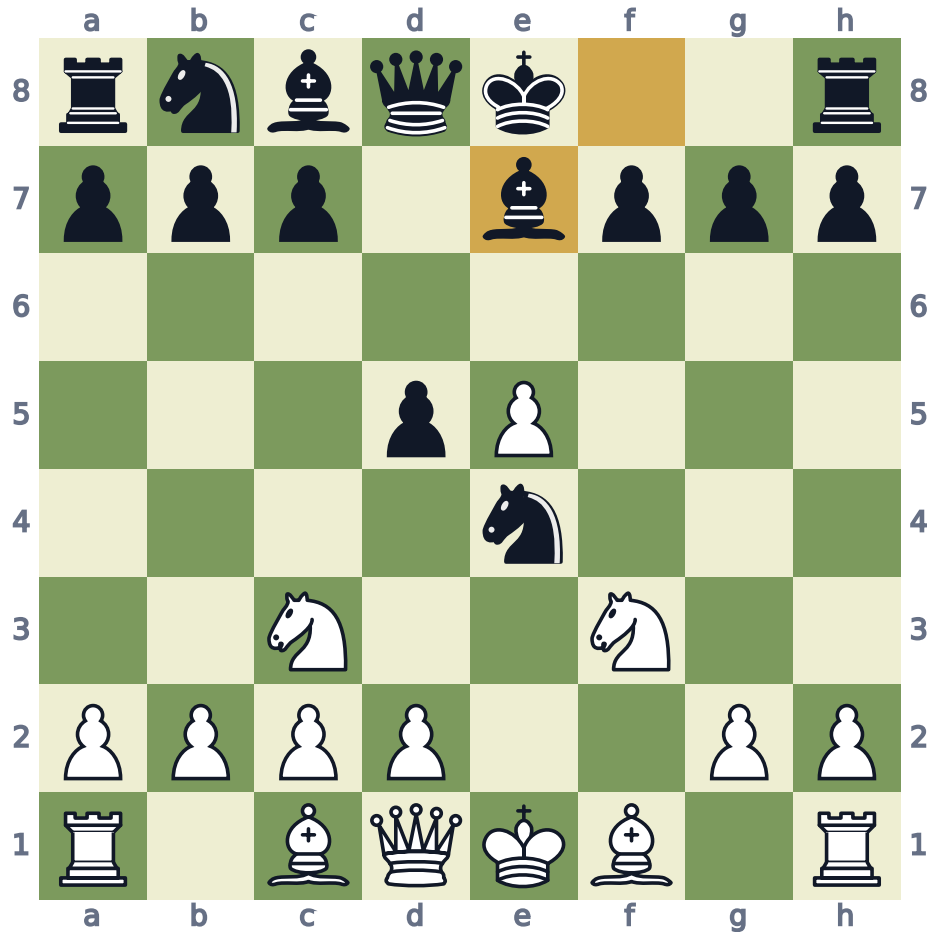
12.5 Scandinavian Defense: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 12

Think, record, then compare



3. f4 d5 4. fxe5 Nxe4 5. Nf3 Be7

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 12

Rubrics, not guesses

12.1 Full credit requires the rule (Fast development and a direct contest for d4 and f7.), the reason (Build d4, castle, connect the rooks, and use e5 or d5 when the center allows it.), a cue (White's d4 is the main freeing break; Black often answers with ...d5.), and the limitation (Attacking f7 repeatedly while the king remains in the center.).

12.2 Full credit requires the rule (White opens the center immediately and asks Black's pieces concrete questions.), the reason (Use the space from e5, develop rapidly, and target the altered queenside pawns.), a cue (Black's ...d6 or ...d5 challenges White's advanced e-pawn.), and the limitation (Trading in the center and then making extra queen moves while pieces remain home.).

12.3 Full credit requires the rule (Flexible development with the option of a fast f-pawn attack.), the reason (Support e4, use f4 to challenge e5, and open lines only with pieces ready.), a cue (White's f4 is the signature break; Black's ...d5 is the principled reply.), and the limitation (Playing f4, f5, and g4 without developing or checking the center.).

12.4 Full credit requires the rule (Black mirrors the attack on e4 and aims for active equality rather than passive defense.), the reason (Use the lead in space, challenge the e4-knight, and create an isolated-pawn or open-center target.), a cue (c4 challenges Black's d5 anchor; ...c6 reinforces or prepares a later queenside expansion.), and the limitation (Copying Nxe4 before driving White's knight from e5.).

12.5 Full credit requires the rule (Black challenges e4 on move one and accepts queen tempi for a clear structure.), the reason (Develop with tempo, occupy the center, and use the space lead before it disappears.), a cue (Black's ...c5 challenges d4; White may use d5 if development supports the advance.), and the limitation (Chasing the queen with pawns that weaken White's own position.).

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 13

Opening-to-Middlegame Transitions

PURPOSE

Move beyond memorization by connecting every opening to its pawn breaks, piece placements, tactical motifs, common mistakes, and first middlegame decision.

13.1 Italian Game: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

13.2 Caro-Kann Defense: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

13.3 Sicilian Alapin: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

13.4 Semi-Slav Defense: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

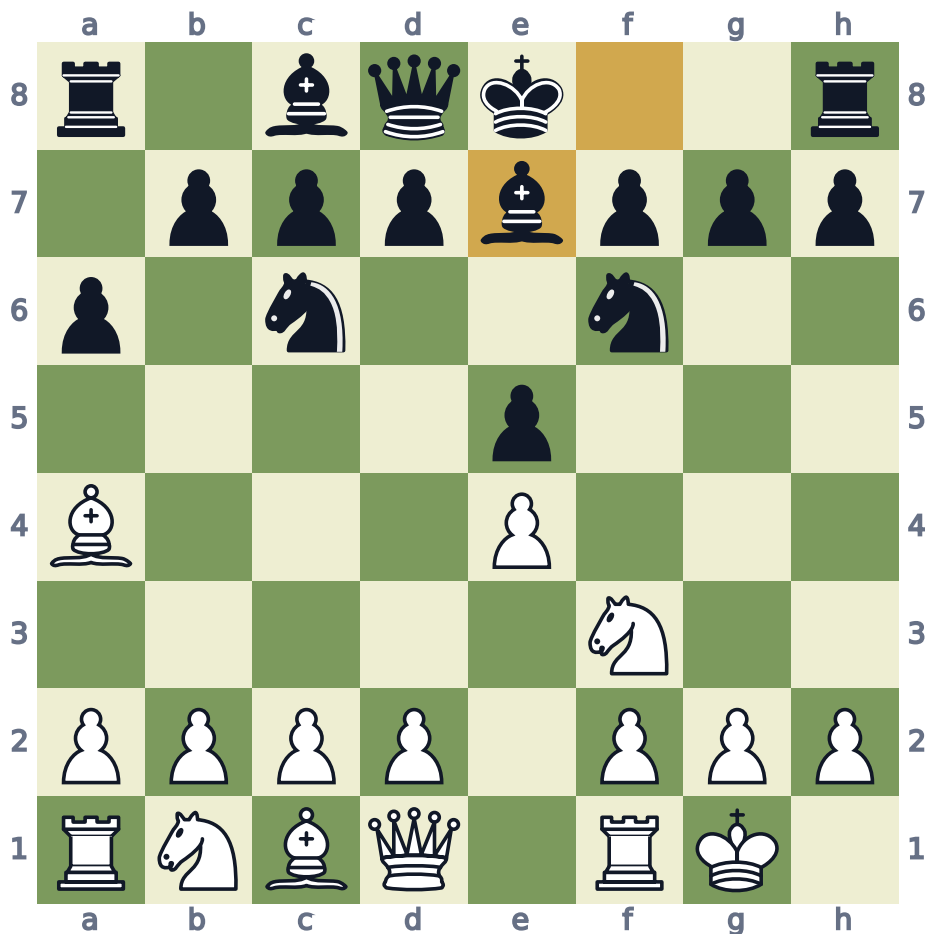
13.5 Reti Opening: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 13

Think, record, then compare



3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 13

Rubrics, not guesses

13.1 Full credit requires the rule (Fast development and a direct contest for d4 and f7.), the reason (Build d4, castle, connect the rooks, and use e5 or d5 when the center allows it.), a cue (White's d4 is the main freeing break; Black often answers with ...d5.), and the limitation (Attacking f7 repeatedly while the king remains in the center.).

13.2 Full credit requires the rule (Black builds a sound center while keeping the light bishop outside the pawn chain.), the reason (Use space, develop without blocking the center, and respond accurately to ...c5.), a cue (...c5 is the main equalizing lever; ...f6 may attack e5 later.), and the limitation (Spending many tempi trapping the bishop while Black breaks open the center.).

13.3 Full credit requires the rule (White prepares d4 with a pawn, aiming for a broad classical center.), the reason (Build the center, develop behind it, and use space without overprotecting every pawn.), a cue (Black's ...d5 or ...d6 attacks the center; White may advance e5 for space.), and the limitation (Recapturing automatically without checking whether isolated pawns and piece activity favor Black.).

13.4 Full credit requires the rule (Black combines Slav solidity with ...e6, creating a compact but very dynamic structure.), the reason (Develop quickly, use e4 when possible, and exploit the time Black spends on queenside expansion.), a cue (...c5 and ...e5 are the central liberating breaks.), and the limitation (Memorizing sharp branches before understanding why Black takes on c4.).

13.5 Full credit requires the rule (White develops and controls central squares before committing central pawns.), the reason (Fianchetto, castle, then choose e4, c4, or d4 according to Black's structure.), a cue (White's e4 or c4 defines the later opening; Black uses ...c5 to secure space.), and the limitation (Confusing flexibility with aimlessness and making only quiet moves.).

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

WORKBOOK SECTION 14

Practical Chess Psychology

PURPOSE

Make your chess process stable when the clock, opponent, result, or emotions create pressure, then turn every serious game into targeted training.

14.1 Perform a Blunder Check: Explain the rule in your own words and name the causal mechanism.

14.2 Practice at the Edge of Your Ability: Give two recognition cues and one important exception.

14.3 Respond to Opening Surprises With Fundamentals: List three candidate moves a position with this theme might suggest, then name the best defensive reply you would test first.

14.4 Retrieve Before You Review: Describe a position from one of your games where this idea should have changed your decision.

14.5 Separate Opening Memory from Understanding: Design a five-minute drill that trains recognition rather than passive familiarity.

DO NOT GRADE YET

Answer without the source course. Confidence is not the score; retrieval plus an accurate mechanism is the score.

BOARD EXERCISE 14

Think, record, then compare



6... Nf6 7. Qe2 d6 8. c4 Be7 9. Nc3

WRITTEN CALCULATION

1. Inventory material, kings, loose pieces, structure, and immediate threats. 2. List three candidates. 3. Calculate the strongest defensive reply to each. 4. Evaluate each endpoint. 5. State which course principle influenced the final choice and why.

ANSWER KEY 14

Rubrics, not guesses

14.1 Full credit requires the rule (Before committing a move, scan the destination and resulting position for checks, captures, and one-move threats by the opponent.), the reason (Many rating points are lost to unforced tactical oversights rather than deep strategic misunderstanding. A short final scan catches high-cost errors cheaply.), a cue (Every move, especially when moving a defender, pushing a pawn, or feeling excited about an attack.), and the limitation (The scan must be brief enough to use consistently and cannot replace deeper calculation in critica...

14.2 Full credit requires the rule (Choose tasks difficult enough to produce errors but clear enough to support focused correction.), the reason (Improvement requires adapting to manageable failure. Tasks that are always easy reinforce comfort; tasks far beyond reach produce guessing.), a cue (Puzzle accuracy near 100 percent; no mistakes in drills; or constant failure without understanding.), and the limitation (Difficulty must be paired with feedback and repetition. Struggle alone is not deliberate practice.).

14.3 Full credit requires the rule (When theory ends unexpectedly, restore center, development, king safety, and threat awareness before improvising.), the reason (Surprise aims to consume time and confidence. General opening priorities reconstruct a sound path without needing exact memory.), a cue (Clock, opponent, score situation, or emotion influences the decision; the board offers several objectively similar choices), and the limitation (Practical considerations never make an unsound move sound. Use them to choose among defensible options, not to igno...

14.4 Full credit requires the rule (Attempt to recall the move, plan, or explanation before reopening notes.), the reason (Retrieval strengthens access pathways and reveals genuine memory gaps. Rereading creates familiarity that can be mistaken for mastery.), a cue (Knowledge fails to appear during games; the same error recurs; study feels familiar but performance does not improve), and the limitation (Training methods work only when tied to feedback and actual game errors. More volume is not automatically more learning.).

14.5 Full credit requires the rule (When an opening goes wrong, decide whether you forgot a move, misunderstood its purpose, or failed after leaving theory.), the reason (Each diagnosis implies different study. Recall needs retrieval practice; misunderstanding needs model positions and explanations; later decision errors belong to calculation or strategy rather than more memorization.), a cue (a game has just finished; your evaluation changed sharply; you spent unusual time; you missed a candidate or repeated a familiar error), and the limitation (Engine evaluations...

BOARD SCORE

Award one point each for accurate inventory, serious candidates, best-defense search, legal calculation, balanced evaluation, and a clear principle-based explanation. Maximum: 6.

GAME ANALYSIS

Decision log for every serious game

Move and clock time

What changed on the previous move?

Candidates considered

Opponent's best reply

Evaluation of the endpoint

What I missed or misjudged

Error class: seeing, candidate, calculation, evaluation, knowledge, time, emotion

Replacement question for the next game

WEEKLY SYSTEM

A twelve-week improvement cycle

MONDAY

Tactics and anti-blunder: 30 minutes of mixed motifs plus ten final-check repetitions.

TUESDAY

Calculation: three positions with a written tree, no moving pieces, then verification.

WEDNESDAY

Endgames and structures: one exact ending plus one pawn-structure plan map.

THURSDAY

Model game or opening transition: pause at every structural change and predict.

FRIDAY

Slow training game. Record time and candidates at the three most critical moments.

SATURDAY

Analyze unaided, classify errors, then use an engine only to test conclusions.

SUNDAY

Spaced review and rest. Retrieve missed items; do not add new material.

TWELVE-WEEK RULE

Keep the weekly structure, but change the primary course every two weeks. Improvement comes from transfer into slow games, not from finishing pages quickly.

RETRIEVAL TEST

Can you explain the course without looking?

1

State the five-step decision protocol from memory.

2

Name three recognition cues that should make you slow down.

3

Choose five learning units and explain the causal mechanism behind each rule.

4

For each chosen rule, give one position where it should not be applied mechanically.

5

Describe the opponent's strongest practical resource in your most recent serious game.

6

Name one recurring error and the exact training drill that addresses its cause.

SCORING

2 points: accurate rule plus mechanism. 1 point: useful but incomplete. 0 points: slogan only. Restudy any item below 2 and retrieve it again tomorrow.

TRAINING PLAN

Four weeks to make the ideas usable

WEEK 1 - UNDERSTAND

Study the first quarter of the course. After every lesson, explain why the rule works and when it fails.

WEEK 2 - RECOGNIZE

Study the second quarter. Mix old and new diagrams so the name of the motif is not given in advance.

WEEK 3 - CALCULATE

Finish the course. Use a clock and write candidates, best defense, and endpoint evaluation.

WEEK 4 - TRANSFER

Play two slow games. Mark every moment when the course's protocol changed your decision, then analyze unaided.

LONG-TERM REVIEW

Return after 7, 14, and 30 days. Do not reread first. Attempt the retrieval test, review only missed items, and find one example from your own games.

REFERENCE

How this course fits the library

COURSE ROLE

Convert the entire library into practice with structured prompts, board laboratories, error classification, spaced review, and weekly planning.

LIBRARY PRINCIPLE

Strong chess comes from a loop: notice the right features, generate serious candidates, calculate the opponent's best resistance, evaluate the destination position, and learn from the decision process.

ABOUT THE DIAGRAMS

Boards use Cburnett-style vector chess pieces with solid dark pieces and high-contrast olive and cream squares. Piece artwork is credited to Colin M. L. Burnett and the Lichess Cburnett set under GPLv2+.

EDITION NOTES

First edition, September 2026. 75 learning units. Explanations and exercises are designed for personal study and should be tested against actual games and concrete calculation.

THE FINAL QUESTION

What will you do differently on your very next move? If the course has not changed a behavior, choose one rule, attach it to a visible board cue, and practice it in five slow games.